

rapidly changing business environment.

Year One: Achieving Failure

Greg witnessed this breakdown in 2009, his first year on the QuickBooks team. That year, the company shipped an entirely new system in QuickBooks for online banking, one of its most important features. The team went through rounds of usability testing using mock-ups and nonfunctional prototypes, followed by significant beta testing using sample customer data. At the moment of the launch, everything looked good.

The first beta release was in June, and customer feedback started coming in negative. Although customers were complaining, there wasn't sufficient cause to stop the release because it was technically flawless—it didn't crash computers. At that point, Greg was in a bind. He had no way of knowing how the feedback would translate to real customer behavior in the market. Were these just isolated complaints, or part of a widespread problem? He did know one thing for sure, though: that his team could not afford to miss the deadline.

When the product finally shipped, the results were terrible. It took customers four to five times longer to reconcile their banking transactions than it had with the older version. In the end, Greg's team had failed to deliver on the customer need they were trying to address (despite building the product to specification), and because the next release had to go through the same waterfall process, it took the team nine months to fix. This is a classic case of “achieving failure”—successfully executing a flawed plan.

Intuit uses a tracking survey called the Net Promoter Score² to evaluate customer satisfaction with its many products. This is a great source of actionable metrics about what customers really think about a product. In fact, I used it at IMVU, too. One thing that is nice about NPS is that it is very stable over time. Since it is measuring core customer satisfaction, it is not subject to minor fluctuations: it registers only major changes in customer sentiment.